

MODEL REFERENCE

# Illustrious / NoobAI Prompting

Master Guide

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**Scope** Danbooru-trained SDXL models

**Covers** Settings · syntax · tag order · negatives · hybrid prompting

**Updated** June 2026

# 1. The one thing to understand first

Illustrious and NoobAI are trained on **Danbooru2023 only** (no e621, no Pony datasets), at 1024×1024 with comma-separated Danbooru tags. What follows from that:

- They speak the **Danbooru tag** language natively, and thanks to SDXL's text encoders they also understand **natural-language description**. They're bilingual. The strongest results usually come from a **hybrid** of both.
- **Pony score tags** (`score_9`, `score_8_up`, ...) **are meaningless here**. They were trained on a different dataset. On Illustrious/NoobAI they're noise, so strip them.
- A "one-size-fits-all" prompt from another model family will usually look muddy. Always read the specific model or merge card first. Creators add their own trigger words and quirks.

# 2. Generation settings

| Setting           | Recommended                                                                | Notes                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sampler</b>    | <b>Euler a</b>                                                             | Safest default on IL/NoobAI. DPM++ 2M Karras can work, especially in generator systems that explicitly recommend it, but can leave more noise on some IL/NoobAI merges.                                                |
| <b>CFG scale</b>  | <b>4.5-5.5</b> sweet spot                                                  | Full usable band 3.0-7.5. Above ~7 tends to oversaturate.                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Steps</b>      | <b>20-24</b>                                                               | 20 is a solid default, 24 for more detail. Follow LoRA or merge recommendations when given.                                                                                                                            |
| <b>CLIP skip</b>  | <b>2</b>                                                                   | Recommended default for Danbooru-trained models where the UI exposes it. In ComfyUI and some SDXL workflows CLIP skip is hidden or handled differently. Follow the checkpoint or workflow recommendation in that case. |
| <b>Resolution</b> | 1024×1024, or portrait 832×1216 / 768×1344 / 896×1152. Landscape 1216×832. | Keep to SDXL-friendly aspect ratios.                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Hires fix</b>  | ×1.5 scale, denoise <b>0.4-0.5</b> , ~16 hires steps                       | ×2.0 and up tends to introduce errors. Nearest-exact upscaler works well. Reuse Euler a as the hires sampler.                                                                                                          |
| <b>ADetailer</b>  | face + hand pass                                                           | Especially for unusual angles where extremities break down.                                                                                                                                                            |

### 3. Prompt syntax rules

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- **All lowercase**, except tags that genuinely contain caps.
- **Commas are mandatory**. The model was trained with them. `sleeveless, striped shirt, collared shirt` , `sleeveless striped collared shirt` .
- **Underscores inside tags are fine** and equivalent to spaces (`open_mouth` = `open mouth`). Use underscores to keep a compound concept together when a sub-string is itself a strong tag (e.g. `fake_rabbit_ears` so it isn't read as `rabbit ears`).
- **Escape symbols** in A1111 with a backslash: `\(` , `\)` , `\:` , etc.
- **Don't repeat a tag** to strengthen it. Use weighting or reposition it instead.
- **75-token CLIP segments**. Front-load the decisive tokens. `BREAK` forces a new segment, supported in Forge and ComfyUI with the right nodes. It doesn't work in vanilla A1111 base, vanilla Diffusers, or onsite generators (those also lack prompt weighting). For weighting in ComfyUI use ADV\_CLIP. In Diffusers use `sd_embed`.

#### Tags that are weak or unreliable

`4k` , `8k` , `hdr` , `high quality` , `detailed` , `ultra-detailed` , `hyper-detailed` : not real Danbooru control tags. They may act as vague aesthetic noise or a mild style bias, but **don't rely on them for real quality or resolution**. Some community prompts still use them as anchors (especially `ultra-detailed` ); treat that as a convention, not a general Danbooru rule.

`score_9` , `score_8_up` and other Pony score tags: **remove entirely** unless the checkpoint or merge explicitly says it was trained to understand them.

Tags with <100 Danbooru posts are often unreliable. Ambiguous tags like `contortion` or `halo` can give unpredictable output.

#### Resolution tags ≠ output resolution

`lowres` , `highres` , `absurdres` are dataset/style metadata describing the *training* image size, not render settings. Set actual resolution in your UI. `absurdres` is commonly used as an illustrious quality or style anchor and is fine for that, but `4k` , `8k` , and `highres` shouldn't be treated as real resolution controls.

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### 4. Tag order (this affects the output)

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**There is no single universal order**. The community describe several valid orders depending on what you're doing. They all work in their own context:

- **Paper / strict Danbooru order**: `person count → character name → rating → general tags → artist → year` . Use this for clean, tag-only prompts close to dataset captions.
- **Practical manual order**: quality anchors up front, then count/character/body top-to-bottom/pose/camera+background/lighting. Use this for hand-built prompts where you want emphasis from front-loading quality and key subject tokens.

- **TIPO / upsampled-caption order:** `count + character` → natural-language sentence(s) → tag list → quality anchors at the end. Use this for long, narrative, or hybrid prompts.

Mixing the *concepts* between orders is fine. What you don't want is to invent a fourth order that contradicts all of them.

## Paper order: worked example

```
1boy, kinoshita hideyoshi, general, building, itomugi-kun, masterpiece, newest
```

1. person count = `1boy` · 2. character = `kinoshita hideyoshi` · 3. rating = `general` · 4. general = `building` · 5. artist = `itomugi-kun` · 6. quality = `masterpiece` · 7. year = `newest`

Character, rating, and artist slots are optional within this order.

## A fuller working structure

1. Character count ( `1girl` , `2girls` )
2. Character name(s)
3. Quality tags
4. Physical features and clothing, **top to bottom**: skin/head/hair → eyes/expression → neck/neckwear → upper torso + attire → lower torso + attire → legs/feet + attire → overall attire, jewelry, tail/wings
5. Pose and anatomy (gestures, posture, on-object)
6. Camera position and background (angle, view, composition, focus, background)
7. Lighting, depth, after-effects

A `BREAK` between the character block, the camera/background block, and the lighting block can sharpen compositional boundaries where supported.

## 5. Quality / style / era tags

**Paper-minimal anchors** (technically all you need): `masterpiece` , `absurdres` , `newest` , plus optional `general` for SFW.

### Reliable expanded set:

```
masterpiece, best quality, amazing quality, very aesthetic, absurdres, newest
```

Alternative emphasis helper (start or end of prompt):

```
(masterwork, [image type], [character name], [artist], award-winning, masterpiece, best quality, hyper-detailed::1.4)
```

For 2.5D or semi-real looks, `ambient occlusion`, `raytracing` help. Test first, since they can look synthetic.

**Era tags:** newest, recent, mid, modern, early, old, oldest. **Year-style tags:** 2020s\_(style), 2000s\_(style), 1980s\_(style), plus retro artstyle, anime screenshot. **Mediums:** traditional media, watercolor (medium), graphite (medium), colored pencil (medium), marker (medium), photo (medium). **Artists:** they need 100+ posts to work reliably. Find them via Danbooru related\_tag, and downweight with (artist\_name:0.5).

Note: don't move or drop the front quality anchors casually. They're load-bearing, and the model weighs everything downstream relative to them.

## Don't stack competing styles

Combining multiple style or medium tokens in one prompt (e.g. watercolor, oil painting, anime screenshot, photorealistic, 3d render) usually weakens coherence and produces a muddy average. Pick **one primary style** and at most **one supporting medium or effect**.

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## 6. Rating tags (SFW/NSFW steering)

Danbooru's 2022 system, recognized by the model:

- general: SFW, all ages. Introduced late and filters ~99% of content, so omit unless you want clean output.
- sensitive: soft fanservice
- questionable: mildly NSFW
- explicit: adult / NSFW

A known IL/NoobAI quirk: bare masterpiece, best quality can drift toward NSFW where another model wouldn't. That reflects training data, so steer with rating tags and a tailored negative.

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## 7. Negative prompts

These models need negatives more than most, but **don't overload**. 30+ vague tags become unpredictable. Better to write accurate positives.

### Solid general baseline:

worst quality, low quality, lowres, bad anatomy, bad hands, missing fingers, extra digits, fewer digits, jpeg artifacts, signature, watermark, username, text, multiple views, displeasing, very displeasing, monochrome, greyscale, sketch, comic

### Short alternative:

lowres, worst quality, bad quality, bad anatomy, sketch, jpeg artifacts, signature, watermark, artist name, old, oldest

**Style-enforcing additions:** for anime, add `photorealistic, photography, 3d render` to negatives. For photoreal, add `anime, drawing, cartoon, painting, illustration`.

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## 8. Hybrid prompting (the modern default)

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Use natural language to set the scene and mood, then tags to nail the specifics:

```
masterpiece, best quality, a cinematic portrait of a beautiful woman in a cyberpunk city,
(red hair:1.2), green eyes, intricate mechanical details, solo, (glowing neon signs:1.1),
detailed background
```

For complex outputs, the **upsampled-caption (TIPO-style)** structure works very well: 1. `person count, character name` 2. natural-language description, sentences separated by periods 3. detailed tag list 4. quality tags at the very end

```
1girl, hatsune miku. An illustration of a girl with long white hair and wings, wearing a
school uniform with a red bow and headphones, wings spread behind her. solo, skirt,
feathered wings, necktie, very long hair, collared shirt, headset, blue eyes, looking at
viewer, twintails, thighhighs, full body, standing, angel wings, masterpiece, general
```

## 9. Multiple characters

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Separate characters:

```
char count, character names, position of the characters, quality
```

For example: `2girls, otonose kanade, hatsune miku, side-by-side, masterpiece`.

Merge two characters into one figure (cosplay trick):

```
1girl, [char A], [char B] (cosplay), quality, physical attributes to preserve
```

For example:

```
1girl, otonose kanade, hatsune miku (cosplay), general, masterpiece, blonde hair
```

Per-character description blocks separated by `BREAK` keep features from bleeding between figures.

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## 10. Backgrounds

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Build in layers: 1. **Environment base:**

```
detailed environment, [location type], clear composition
```

2. **Architectural or natural**

**elements:** materials, structures, decorative details 3. **Lighting and atmosphere:** time of day, light type, atmospheric effects

Examples:

- *Indoor:* luxurious room, detailed architecture, marble floor, ornate furniture, crystal chandeliers, tall windows, warm ambient lighting, soft shadows, volumetric lighting
- *Urban:* detailed cityscape, modern architecture, glass buildings, city streets, store fronts, night scene, neon lighting, street lamps, ambient occlusion
- *Nature:* detailed landscape, rolling hills, dense forest, flowing water, detailed foliage, golden hour lighting, atmospheric haze, dynamic clouds

Keep character and background lighting consistent. Add depth markers ( foreground , midground , background ), and keep perspective consistent with the pose. Useful Danbooru tag groups: image\_composition, focus\_tags, backgrounds, lighting, colors.

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## 11. Camera, angle and lighting tags

**Angles/composition:** from above , from below , from side , straight-on , three-quarter view , close-up , portrait , upper body , full body , wide shot , POV , dutch angle , fisheye , isometric , foreshortening , head out of frame , vanishing point , symmetry .

**Lighting:** cinematic lighting , rim light , backlighting , soft lighting , harsh lighting , dramatic lighting , volumetric lighting , soft shadows , film-style contrast , bloom .

**Effects/depth:** depth of field , blurry foreground , blurry background , bokeh , spot color , chromatic aberration , glitch .

Place angle tags after the quality tags near the front. Lighting tags work at the start or very end. Expect to fiddle with position and wording.

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## 12. Edit / inpainting workflow

For inpainting, **don't paste the full original prompt** unless the whole image needs to be reinterpreted. Prompt only the masked region, matching the surrounding lighting and style.

Good (replacing a door):

ornate wooden door, carved wood patterns, brass handle, warm lighting, soft shadows, highly detailed

Bad (full scene re-prompt):

1girl, living room, sofa, window, full background, ornate wooden door, ...

Denoising strength: **0.3-0.6** for subtle edits, **0.7-0.85** for major changes. Steps 20-30, CFG 5-7, mask blur ~4px for clean edges.

Inpainting-specific negative additions (on top of your baseline):

seams, blending artifacts, inconsistent lighting, duplicate, oversharpen, oversaturated

For full-image img2img (style or detail adjustment rather than a localized edit), use a full positive prompt that emphasizes the desired *change*, not the parts you want to preserve.

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## 13. Visible-first principle

**Prompt what the camera can see. Omit hidden backstory, internal emotion, off-screen lore, or anything that doesn't produce visible detail.** Story context that won't render is just noise that competes with your visible tokens.

- Weak: `a princess secretly afraid of losing her kingdom`
- Strong: `princess, anxious expression, trembling hands, tearful eyes, dark throne room`

Same principle for POV scenes: don't describe the unseen first-person actor, describe what's actually framed.

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## 14. Embeddings (workflow accelerators)

Textual inversions bundle a concept into one trigger word: 1. **Negative embeddings**: one word in the negative replaces a long anti-tag list. 2. **Aesthetic / "style in a can"**: capture an entire art style. 3. **Character / concept**: consistent characters, backgrounds, lighting styles. 4. **System/technique**: e.g. Pony-score embeds (Pony only). Advanced users can merge embeddings with the Embedding Merge extension.

Always check the model card for the embedding's intended trigger and base model. An SDXL/IL embedding won't behave on a Pony model and vice versa.

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## 15. Quick checklist

- ☐ **Check the model/merge/LoRA card first.** Local recommendations override this generic guide.
- ☐ Euler a · CFG ~5 · 20-24 steps · CLIP skip 2 (where the UI exposes it) · SDXL-friendly resolution
- ☐ Lowercase, comma-separated, no repeated tags
- ☐ Pick a tag order that fits the task (paper / practical / TIPO) and stick to it
- ☐ Front-load the decisive tokens, with quality anchors present and unmoved



- ☐ No Pony score tags, and treat `8k` / `hdr` / `4k` / `ultra-detailed` as unreliable noise, not real controls
- ☐ One primary style, don't stack competing mediums
- ☐ Visible-first: prompt what the camera can see, not hidden backstory
- ☐ Tight, accurate negative
- ☐ Hybrid (sentence + tags) for complex scenes
- ☐ NSFW: rating `explicit`, adult anchor early, never anything minor-adjacent